

# KF36 Meeting Version of Teachings

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Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

## **0:01    OPENING**

## **0:02    PRESENTING**

## **0:06    KARIS CIRCULATION**

## **0:07    GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS**

## **0:08    MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING**

We will continue with the **Lectio Divina**.

Assume a meditation posture. Scan your body for tension, and relax on the exhale. Collect yourself and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

### **1. Read the passage**

I will read a short sentence from the Bible and then pause. Our encouragement is from Hebrews 12:1.

*Let us run with endurance the challenge set before us.  
(Repeat) (Pause)*

### **2. Receive as you listen**

Relax while I read this Scripture three times, pausing between readings. Take the attitude of a listener. In the stillness between the readings, consider your experience with the words and allow a related feeling, thought, or image to come to mind. If nothing definite comes, observe the absence of these things or just enjoy the stillness. Observe with compassion any other feelings or thoughts that may intrude, and then return to the text. Let's begin. *(Use the singular pronoun for the last reading)*

*Let us (me) run with endurance the challenge set before us (me).  
(Read the passage 3 times, pausing for 30 seconds after each reading)*

### **3. Respond**

Respond to God with affirmation and gratitude. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

### **4. Rest in awareness**

Rest in stillness for one minute as you contemplate what you have experienced during this time. You might allow the words to gently recede and then focus your mind on your breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause and re-engage with your environment. You may wish to take this next minute to record your

experience in a KF journal or on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**, or you might simply wait. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause. You can use this meditation to explore any passage from the Bible that is meaningful to you. Read the Scripture out loud and savor it for ten or fifteen minutes. Let God reorient your spirit with the truth of the words.

At the games in ancient Greece, the judges awarded a crown to the winner of a contest. With that thought in mind, listen to our hymn for KF Confession 8, *And Can It Be?*

No condemnation now I dread.  
Jesus, and all in Him, is mine.  
Alive in Him, my living Head,  
And clothed in righteousness divine.  
Bold I approach the eternal throne  
And claim the crown, through Christ my own!  
Bold I approach the eternal throne  
And claim the crown, through Christ my own!<sup>1</sup>

Take a deep breath.

*(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)*

## **0:20 KARIS CONFESSION**

## **0:21 TOOLBOX**

The process of building strong CORE muscles requires time, and while you are building those muscles, you will have to learn endurance. Most people have not learned the great rewards of endurance because they give up too soon in their training. They are still motivated by instant gratification, snatching at what they hope to gain and losing heart when their goals are not quickly realized. They long for a shortcut that will relieve their tension, even if that shortcut leads them deeper into chaos. They cannot imagine how practicing endurance might benefit them, and their lack of skill prevents them from discovering what marvelous outcomes are possible if they would learn to endure.

### **1. Mindfulness and meditation teach us productive endurance**

The practice of mindfulness and meditation helps us develop the CORE muscle of endurance. In KF meetings, we learn to take small mindfulness steps, but we hope that each one of you will go on to take bigger steps and increase your meditation time. When you practice mindfulness and meditation, your mind and body must endure the self-criticism, anxiety, frustration, and wiggles of boredom that come with learning any new skill. If you learn to endure these tensions, you will increase your capacity to endure tension in other challenging situations. You are presently learning the skill of mindful endurance by practicing meditation in a quiet environment where there are few distractions. This skill can then be applied in far more distracting and stressful circumstances. You must learn to sail on a sheltered lake before launching out onto the ocean.

During your meditation time, you may have had these thoughts: *I can't do this. I can't do it right. I don't want to be doing this. This isn't working. I'm too tired. I'm wasting my time. I've got a dozen other things to do. Will the timer ever ring? I'm so bored!* It's quite natural to think and feel this way.

Learning to meditate requires endurance—and aren't these exactly the kind of thoughts and feelings you have in any place of endurance? The untrained parts of you are being stretched, and they have lots of strong feelings about that! The Idol Self uses these feelings to discourage you from developing the endurance you need to become real and glorious.

## 2. Listening to another person teaches us productive endurance

The practice of listening attentively during the sharing and teaching times trains you to endure productively. You learn how to be aware, intentional, and mindful when someone is talking—and that includes God and yourself. God often tells us to listen up. He isn't kidding!

## 3. Practicing endurance trains us for life's difficulties

Without training in productive endurance, you will find it much more difficult to manage your anxiety and respond to life's experiments with orientation. Your business is to practice endurance and give it a chance to accomplish the oriented outcome of developing virtue and a trustworthy character.<sup>2</sup> Whenever you meditate, pray, or listen to others, you strengthen the core muscle of endurance. Life is difficult, and if you haven't learned to endure for even a few minutes, how can you hope to endure for the long run?

If you are suffering and finding it hard to endure, try working through the worksheet **Suffering: An Opportunity to see Yourself**, and bear in mind that you may be inflicting suffering on yourself. You are often reluctant to examine your own suffering because that suffering is serving your neurotic goals—your Idol Self is getting something out of it. You might, for example, be using your suffering to punish yourself or others. Suffering can also be a convenient excuse to avoid responsibility or to avoid working on your own healing. Perhaps you use suffering to make yourself and others feel guilty. You can then extort support, sympathy, attention, and even admiration.

When we refuse to honor our limitations and those of others, we often cause our own suffering. We push, shove, and force to the point of exhaustion and to the detriment of our health and are unwilling to learn to be patient in our discomfort. Instead, we cling to the belief that we are like gods and can get what we want if we push hard enough. Then, if our circumstances are not magically transformed, we blame God or others for our suffering. In our karis relationship with God, however, suffering becomes an invitation to acknowledge our limitations and train our ability to live in reality. If you refuse that training, you simply will not have the strength to productively endure adversity. Under stress, you will default to old habits of saving your life and cause more suffering.

Your Idol has loaded you with the baggage of its misorientation, and that heavy weight prevents you from running your race with endurance. In Karis Fellowships, we are working hard to unload this extra weight and strengthen our capacity to endure. We want to run.

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Lord of an easy yoke, I am willing and ready to unload the Idol's weight.<sup>3</sup> (Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

*(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")*

## 0:30 SHARING

## 1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

People in the first century were trained to remember the context of a portion of Scripture. Following that tradition, Nancy has incorporated ideas from chapter 11 in her paraphrase of **Hebrews 12:1–17**. As you listen to the text for this lesson, notice how the author uses the words *endurance*, *discipline*, and *training*.

<sup>1</sup>When we consider all those who have gone before us into a better country—those who acted on their beliefs and who already know by experience what we are coming to know—we are encouraged to keep moving toward that country set apart for us by God. Therefore, lay aside the heavy weight of the Idol Self and its misorientation, which so easily entangles us. Let us run with endurance the challenge stretching out before us and <sup>2</sup>fix our sights on the beacon light of Jesus, who by the example of His choices leads us forward. He accomplished the goal of showing us the way home. He endured the cross and exchanged it for joy. He resisted self-hate and took His place of authority next to the throne of God. That is your path, too. <sup>3</sup>You might consider this: Jesus, our Lord and leader, endured the same kinds of misoriented people that you endure—people who resist the person of Jesus in their thoughts and choices. His example encourages us not to abandon our True Self or become weary in our efforts.

<sup>4</sup>Let's get real. You can still do better in your striving against misorientation. Your efforts haven't killed you yet! <sup>5</sup>You have forgotten the firm guidance that is addressed to you as sons: "My son, do not undervalue the discipline of God, believing that it's not worthwhile, and do not faint when He corrects you, judging that His correction and discipline are too hard and unfair. <sup>6</sup>Why do we engage with His training? Because God only disciplines those whom He loves, and every son that He receives as a candidate for training He thoroughly corrects."

<sup>7</sup>You endure in order to be trained. In other words, your training requires your endurance. God is dealing with you as He would deal with sons. Think about this: What kind of father would not train his own son? <sup>8</sup>Everyone has received some sort of training, but if you are not trained by God, then you are not of God's lineage—you are not His son. <sup>9</sup>Before we were accepted as sons of God, we were trained by fathers of our material lineage, and we turned toward their way of doing things, which did not help us much. We would do better to come under the management of the Father of our spiritual lineage, and live. <sup>10</sup>Let me explain what I mean. Our material fathers trained us for a short time according to what they thought was best, but often not according to what we needed. God, however, trains us according to what would benefit us now and profit us in the better country that He has set apart for us. <sup>11</sup>For all training seems grievous and difficult rather than fun. But if we make our training an exercise in orientation, it will eventually reward us with the fruit of peace.

<sup>12</sup>That being the case, restore to action the hands that have given up out of exhaustion and set straight the knees that are wobbling from effort. <sup>13</sup>Stop wasting your energy in bad training that causes exhaustion and wobbling. Get going in the right direction so that you can heal your ability to work and to run.

<sup>14</sup>Pursue peace with everyone and work toward achieving a life set apart in orientation

and truth. No one will be able to see the Lord in you if you do not achieve that kind of life.

<sup>15</sup>Keep a watch on yourselves and see that no one dawdles behind in their karis relationship with God. Make sure that no one allows a root of bitterness to sprout up where karis should be sprouting up; bitter roots cause trouble and defile many.

<sup>16</sup>Watch over yourselves and see that no sexually untrustworthy persons dwell among you—people who allow themselves to be trodden on by cravings and defilement. Esau was a person like that. He exchanged his precious firstborn rights for simple food, just because he could not endure a little discomfort. <sup>17</sup>You know how that turned out. Even afterwards, when Esau wished to inherit favor and the blessing, he was rejected as a candidate because he had shown himself unworthy to be a son. As an untrustworthy person, he had refused the karis training. He could not undo the damage he had done even though he sought to do so with tears, because tears are not a substitute for trustworthy action.

Take a deep breath.

This passage is rich in ideas, and you might explore some of them for yourself. Here's what Nancy would like you to remember.

### **1. We all have a race to run**

Each of us has a different race to run—a contest or challenge that stretches out before us—but the goal is always the same: to develop the character of Jesus in our lives.

### **2. We endure tough things because we have a goal**

We are in training for our mission and for our joy—and to bring God joy. Our lives are becoming a holy place in a very unholy world. At times, God's training might feel severe, but that is only our perception and not the reality, for we know that the burden Jesus lays upon us is easy, and His yoke is light.<sup>4</sup> One of the benefits of training is the discovery of how weak we actually are; we discover how much our misorientation is interfering with our efforts to run with endurance.

### **3. We can choose to strengthen our own souls for the contest**

Don't dawdle at the starting post out of laziness or the fear of suffering, and don't give up at the first discouraging hurdle. The race set before you is the opportunity that you need to build up your soul. Every hurdle has the potential to increase your joy. Productive suffering turning to joy is one of the cycles of life.<sup>5</sup>

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Heavenly Parent, teach me to courageously run my own contest with endurance. (Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

*(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")*

## **1:10 INTEGRATION**

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe.  
*(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider giving God permission to train you for your contest. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

## **The FAITH Process**

### **Feelings**

As you *consider giving God permission to train you for your contest*, recognize what you are feeling. Notice what is happening inside your skin as you consider giving God this permission. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

### **Awareness without judgment**

Allow your experience to present itself, and welcome that experience into your awareness. You might notice any struggle or tension when you *consider giving God permission to train you for your contest*. *(Pause)* Welcome whatever information that tension brings. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission to explore, without judgment, whatever you are experiencing. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

### **Inquiry: What is my body saying?**

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider giving God permission to train you for your contest*. How does your body respond? *(Pause)* You might notice what fatigue, terror, or even anticipation feels like in your body. You might feel nothing at all. Gently maintain awareness of your body's sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

### **Talk to Jesus**

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of giving God permission to train you for your contest*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or numb? Just observe. *(Pause)* Could there be fear or resistance—or, perhaps, joy? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider giving God this permission? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Do you fear the loss of some aspect of your Idol's search for glory? Does your need for training hurt your pride? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

### **Heal**

As you breathe, repeat to yourself the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

*(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)*

- Welcome this opportunity to explore the challenge set before you.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth, who finds joy in training you.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.<sup>6</sup>

*(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)*

- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for power and control.
- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for esteem and affection.
- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for security and comfort.
- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

*(Optional)* Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Pause. Take a deep breath.

*(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)*

## **1:28    ENDING PRAYER**

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together as we present ourselves to You for training. Hold us in the power of this orientation and continue to guide us to our glory and truth. Prepare the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our true design and mission, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

*(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)*

## **1:29    ANNOUNCEMENTS**

\*If you have the MATH to support the NHG book study, please go to the NHG tab on the KF website and sign up on the NHG Facilitator Signup Spreadsheet.

*(\*Except when preparing for Jubilee Year)*

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<sup>1</sup> *And Can It Be?* by Charles Wesley (1707–1788); [www.youtube.com/watch?v=sQelGbKgiw8](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sQelGbKgiw8).

<sup>2</sup> See KF3.

<sup>3</sup> Matt. 11:28–30.

<sup>4</sup> Matt. 11:30.

<sup>5</sup> Psalm 30:5.

<sup>6</sup> [www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html](https://www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html). Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.